

BEFORE

The spread of Islam on the borders of Europe coincided with the growth of a pious and aggressive warrior society in Western Europe.



ANGEL GABRIEL

THE SPREAD OF ISLAM

In 610 CE, following a visitation from the Angel Gabriel, the prophet Muhammad proclaimed the religion of Allah (God) among the tribes of the Arab Peninsula. Islam took root over much of Asia, North Africa, and parts of Europe << 174–77.

THE EUROPEAN SITUATION

By the 11th century, as opportunities for territorial expansion within Western Europe declined, an aggressive warrior society began to turn its attention to the lands outside Europe's borders. The Christian Byzantine empire << 198–99 had long acted as a buffer between Western Europe and Asia, but in 1071 the Byzantine army was destroyed by the Muslim Seljuk Turks at Manzikert.

The Crusades

For more than two centuries, the Middle East became a battleground in which Christian armies from Europe, inspired by an ideology of legitimate religious warfare, fought Muslims for control of the Holy Land (Palestine).

In 1095 CE, in a small field outside the cathedral at Clermont in France, Pope Urban II made an impassioned appeal. He called for a military expedition to liberate the holy city of Jerusalem and free Christians from the yoke of Muslim rule. In exchange, Urban stated that any soldiers who died fighting the enemy would earn remission from all sins. The crowd erupted with cries of “God wills it!”. Over the next two years alone, thousands of crusaders, as these soldiers became known, took the cross and joined this pilgrimage to the Holy Land.

Foundations of the crusade

Urban's sermon may have been the catalyst, but the roots of the crusades stretch farther

Crusader sword

This type of broad-bladed sword, with simple crossguard and pommel, became popular during the Crusades. It would have been devastating against lightly armored opponents.

back. Most obviously, Urban was responding to the political situation in the east: following the defeat of the Byzantine armies at Manzikert in 1071, the emperor had sent an appeal to the pope for military assistance. Urban saw the proposed expedition east as a chance to flex papal muscles and check the expansion of Islam, as well as an opportunity to conquer what he perceived as pagan areas.

The huge popular response to his appeal, although unexpected, was the product of a number of factors, including the growth of a fervent lay piety over the preceding centuries and the need of a land-hungry warrior class to find an outlet for their martial energies. The crusades united these impulses by legitimizing the concept of religious warfare.

The Church of the Holy Sepulchre had been destroyed by the caliph in 1009. It was rebuilt after the crusaders conquered Jerusalem in 1099.

The Patriarch of Jerusalem was the spiritual leader of the kingdom and representative of the pope in Rome.

Mounted and heavily armored knights formed the heavy shock troops of the crusader armies.



The defense of Jerusalem

Crusader knights guard the Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem. As the traditional site of Jesus's crucifixion and burial, this was the physical destination for pilgrims and crusaders alike.



11th-century religion

Three faiths dominated Europe, North Africa, and the Middle East: Catholicism, Islam, and the Greek Orthodox Church of the Byzantine empire.

The crusades to the east

There were several major expeditions from Europe to the Middle East and Egypt in the period 1095–1272 CE.

1095 Pope Urban II preaches the crusade at the **Council of Clermont**. The response exceeds all expectations.

1189–1192 The **Third Crusade** is led by the kings of France and England and the German Emperor. English king, Richard I, makes a truce with Saladin.

1145–49 The **Second Crusade** fails to recapture Edessa, lost 1144.

1198 The **Fourth Crusade** never reaches the Holy Land. Crusader armies are diverted to fight the Christian Byzantine empire at Constantinople.

1217–21 The **Fifth Crusade** captures Damietta in Egypt but surrenders before reaching Cairo.

1291 Following the fall of the port of **Acre** the remaining Crusader states in the Holy Land are evacuated.

1248–54 The **Seventh Crusade** ends with the capture of Louis IX of France, who is ransomed for 50,000 gold bezants.

